

Common Shallow Sponges of St. Thomas, USVI

Photos by Deborah Gochfeld, IDs by D. Gochfeld & M. Cristina Diaz

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NOAA
CORAL REEF
CONSERVATION PROGRAM



***Mycale laevis*:**
Orange or white, thick encrusting, occurs on undersides and between lobes of corals, clear veins and large oscules



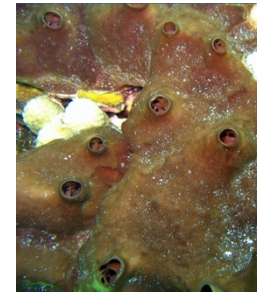
***Mycale laxissima*:**
Purple, red, orange tubes or crust, large oscule with clear collar, surface bumpy or spiny, covered with clear membrane, mucus



***Dictyonella funicularis*:**
Greyish green, very thin, encrusts over coral, rock, algae (shown here) and other sponges, many tiny pores



***Plakortis angulospiculatus*:**
Brown with paler interior, smooth thick encrusting lobes, few large complex oscules



***Svenzea zeai*:**
Brick red to brown, thick encrusting lobes, oscules on small cones, smooth surface, soft, crumbly tan interior



***Svenzea cristinae*:**
Brick red, pink, brown, encrusting or lobes with few large oscules, soft velvety surface with fine lattice pattern, very soft tan interior



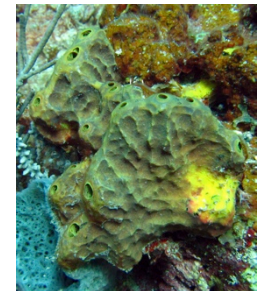
***Ectyoplasia ferox*:**
Bright orange to brown, thick encrusting or massive, oscules on tubes or cones, surface smooth or porous, firm but crumbly



***Aiolochoiria crassa*:**
Yellow, brown, blue, purple & yellow, massive to tubular, rubbery, large rounded bumps on surface, large oscules



***Smenospongia aurea*:**
Green to brown, massive with oscules at ends of cone shaped tubes, honeycomb surface, yellow interior, mucus



***Verongula rigida*:**
Yellow, brown or green, yellow interior, low solitary or grouped tubes or lobes, large oscules on top, ridged surface, blue exudate if damaged



***Ircinia felix*:**
Yellow, orange or brown, massive (picture), cones or branches, bumps on surface, few large oscules, very tough



***Ircinia strobilina*:**
Grey to black, massive globular, surface bumps dense or sparse, tough, oscules on top may be grouped in depressions



***Iotrochota biortulata*:**
Green-black, encrusting or upright, tough, rough surface oscules on top, dark exudate when handled, may host orange zoanthids



***Agelas clathrodes*:**
Bright orange, thick, rubbery, keyhole and round oscules, often fouled, in open or caves



***Desmapsamma anchorata*:**
Light pink, darker interior, thick encrusting with large oscules on tubes or cones, soft, smooth surface, overgrows rock, sponge etc.



***Callyspongia fallax*:**
Grey, purple or blue, small tubes in clusters, large oscules, smooth surface, firm but spongy



***Callyspongia vaginalis*:**
Grey, tan, purple, cluster of tubes or vases, large opening with smooth or spiny rim, surface smooth to small or large spines



***Xestospongia muta*:**
Shades of brown, barrel or vase-shaped, can get very large, brittle, Projections along outer walls



***Cinachyrella* spp.:**
Yellow-orange spherical balls, may be completely fouled, tough, variable number & size of oscules



***Ptilocaulis walpersii*:**
Orange spiny tufts to upright branches or bushes, tough, oscules rarely visible